Social justice through stories

Teacher lesson plan | Read, discuss, respond and connect

Purpose and learning goals

Students circulate among six thematic stations, choose a book from a station's selection and work with a partner. Learning from books is primary: identify a key message, support thinking with words or pictures, explain why the learning matters and connect ideas across books. A required meaningful illustration supports that learning; artistic detail and colouring are secondary.

Set up six book-choice stations

Place an approved sign and a selection of teacher-chosen books at each thematic station, with optional selection input from Laura. Preview books for age suitability, accuracy and respectful representation. Include Indigenous-authored texts at the Indigenous voices station and identify specific Nations or communities when provided. Supply the approved eight-page grayscale booklet, pencils, drawing tools and extra continuation pages (page 8). Offer accessible text/audio and clear, accessible movement routes; bring books to students when needed.

Partner station flow and flexible timing

Introduce the six themes and model choosing a book and discussing evidence. Partners choose a station and book, read or view it together, discuss the station question, then each completes an individual organizer response informed by their discussion. They may take turns reading, listen to an accessible version or examine illustrations together. Allow about 40–60 minutes for one book and response, split across sessions as needed. Partners move when ready and revisit stations over several sessions. No forced timed rotations or requirement to complete every station. Complete page 7 after at least two books. November 20 connects to children's rights, belonging and voice, not a completion deadline.

Before reading or viewing

With partners, introduce the author, illustrator and theme. Ask: What do the title and cover make us wonder? What might belonging or fair participation look like here? Invite predictions as possibilities. Students may discuss books or the world without sharing personal experiences. Agree to listen, share turns, respect stated names and identities, and question ideas without questioning anyone's dignity.

During reading and discussion

Partners pause to ask: What do we notice in the words or pictures? What supports our thinking? Whose perspective are we hearing? Revisit pages when interpretations differ. The teacher circulates, listens and prompts rather than supplying every answer. Name unfairness accurately and attend to agency, resistance, care and joy. Never invent quotations, treat a character as representing a whole community, or reenact oppression.

Other valid ways to use the package

Adapt to the learners and selected books: use a teacher read-aloud, independent study, teacher-guided small groups or one-theme whole-class work. Use the same before/during/after discussion prompts and evidence-based responses in each format.

Respond with evidence

Four organizer sections | Book learning comes first

After reading: discuss, then respond

Partners revisit the station question: What did this book help us understand? Which detail deepened our thinking? Each student then completes their own organizer using ideas explored in discussion; partners need not reach identical interpretations. Model with an actual page when helpful and distinguish evidence from inference. A shared oral response is a valid adaptation when needed, with opportunities for both students to contribute.

1. Main idea or key message

Students state an important message, then use a specific detail from the words or pictures. Prompt: “I think the book helps us understand ___ because ___.” Ask students to point to, describe or reread the evidence. A topic label alone, such as “fairness,” needs explanation.

2. Meaningful illustration

The illustration is required: students draw a scene, picture or symbol that represents the theme in this book and add a short label or caption explaining its meaning. Protect ample drawing space in the organizer; offer a separate sheet if needed. Invite a student to explain how the image connects to a detail in the book. Artistic realism is not the goal. Do not ask students to depict abuse or reenact harm.

3. Why should we learn about this topic?

Students explain what the book helped them understand about people, rights, belonging, relationships or participation. Prompt: “This matters because the book shows ___.” Ask for a link to the text rather than a generic statement that everyone should be kind.

4. Make a connection

Students connect the book to another book, the world or their own life by choice. Prompt: “This reminds me of ___; the connection helps me understand ___.” A text-to-text or teacher-provided real-world connection is always valid. Never require disclosure about identity, family, discrimination, disability, trauma or migration.

Space, access and enrichment

Use page 8 whenever a response needs more room; record the book/topic and question being continued. Accept oral explanation, a scribe, speech-to-text, drawing with labels, home-language responses, supported communication or an adapted shared oral response. Preserve the thinking goal while adapting output and pacing. Complete the meaningful illustration as an explanation of book learning; colouring the themed frame is optional secondary enrichment and should not crowd out reading or discussion.

Connect learning and plan next steps

Six themes | Reflection | Formative assessment

Choose a theme, keep the book central

Indigenous voices: First Nations, Métis and Inuit rights and teachings; honour distinct voices and avoid generalizations. Our shared Earth: sustainability, access to nature and a shared future. Gender, identity and families: explicitly include LGBTQ2S+ voices, sexual orientation, gender identity, diverse families and equal rights. Languages, cultures and communities: include diverse Canadians, languages, traditions and everyday community life, not only immigration. Racism, discrimination and change: examine unfair systems, resistance and change without reenacting oppression or depicting abuse. Accessibility, inclusion and equality: consider visible and non-visible disabilities, barriers and changes supporting full participation; do not simulate disabilities.

Final cross-book reflection • page 7

After at least two books, ask students to name the books they are connecting. Use the booklet's UN Secretary-General prompt: which issue would they focus on, and why? Students connect their choice to at least two books, explain how the books deepened or changed their thinking, and use a real-world example they have learned about to explain a global impact. Provide a verified, age-appropriate example if needed; do not ask students to invent one. Explain that the Secretary-General is a leader who can encourage international cooperation; students are proposing priorities, not claiming one person can solve every issue.

Actions and a message

Students suggest actions for people or governments and explain how these would protect rights. They draw a picture or symbol showing their most important learning and add a caption. Invite specific, feasible ideas and acknowledge the responsibilities of adults and institutions. Use the continuation page as needed. Share by choice, then identify a question to revisit or one class action adults can support.

Formative look-fors

Listen and look for a clear message supported by a relevant detail; an explanation of why the topic matters; a connection that deepens understanding; and an illustration whose meaning the student can explain. In the final reflection, notice links across at least two books, a grounded real-world example and a reasoned rights-protecting action. Use questions and feedback to guide revision rather than an invented scoring rubric. Separate drawing fluency, handwriting and amount of colouring from the student's understanding.

Responsive teaching

If evidence is thin, reread a short passage or image together. If a connection is broad, ask what is similar or different and why that matters. Correct stereotypes calmly and return to accurate language and the specific text. Offer a pause, alternative text or private check-in when needed without requesting an explanation. Optional collaboration with Laura can support book selection or discussion; arrange it separately without assuming a schedule.